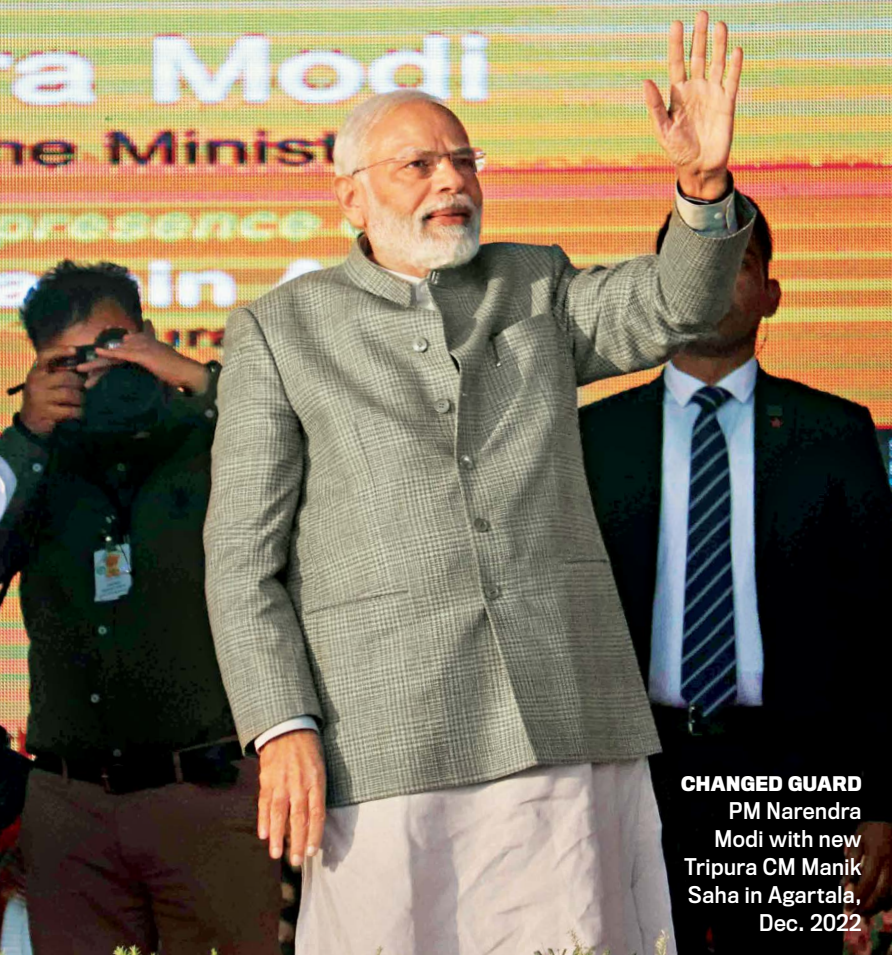


CHANGED GUARD PM Narendra Modi with new Tripura CM Manik Saha in Agartala, Dec. 2022

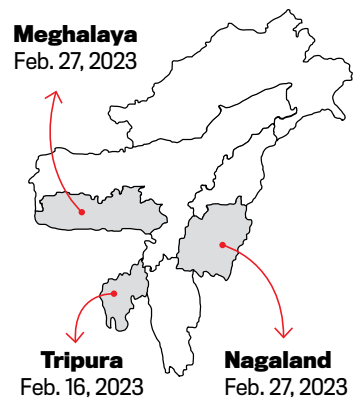
margin was the fact that the CPI(M)'s vote share of 42 per cent closely shadowed the BJP's 44 per cent. The biggest loser was the Congress, with two per cent of the vote share, down from 37 per cent in 2013. More than Left voters, it was Congress voters who switched to the BJP to end the Left hegemony. The new alliance—CPI (M) contesting 46 seats and Congress 13—may change that equation. The Congress can also take heart from the fact that it improved its vote share to 25 per cent in the 2019 Lok Sabha polls. The CPI(M) has also been trying hard to project itself in a new avatar—over 50 per cent of its candidates are new faces. Even former chief minister Manik Sarkar is not contesting the polls. Then there is the Trinamool Congress, which will be targeting the same votes as the Left and Congress and eat into the votes of other parties in Bengali-dominated areas. The BJP hopes that the split in non-BJP votes will work in its favour. Mamata Banerjee's party scored a zero in 2018.

The biggest worry for the BJP is the emergence of Tipra Motha, a new party led by royal scion Pradyot Manikya Debbarma. It has successfully positioned itself as the champion of the indigenous tribals, who constitute 30 per cent of Tripura's population. Last year, a Motha-led alliance swept the Tripura Tribal Areas Autonomous District Council (TTAADC) polls, winning 18 of the 28 seats; the BJP got nine. The BJP tried to form an alliance with Motha, but talks fell through as Debbarma was clear that his party would not join hands with anyone without a written assurance about creating a Greater Tipraland—a separate state comprising the present area under TTAADC and 36 other villages. Debbarma was also in discussion with the IPFT for a tribal alliance, but the BJP managed to retain its ally. The rise of Motha, the death of IPFT founder N.C. Debbarma and the defection of several leaders, including three MLAs, have severely dented IPFT's influence. Consequently, the BJP has offered only five seats to the tribal party, down from 10 last time.

The fear of losing tribal votes was evident in Modi's speech in December when he mentioned that the BJP had swept 24 out of 27 reserved tribal seats in Gujarat and called it the "first choice of tribal society". The party is banking on tribal faces like Deputy CM Jishnu Dev Varma and Patal Kumari Jamatia, who joined it last year, to woo indigenous votes. Recently, three sitting BJP MLAs defected to opposition parties, while a Muslim MLA of the CPI (M) joined the ruling party.

Despite its growing popularity, Tipra Motha still may not have a smooth run in the 20 reserved seats. While tribals influence results in 10 unreserved seats dominated by Bengalis, the latter similarly play a crucial role in seven ST seats. With the Motha espousing a separate tribal state, Bengali votes will most likely go against it. Given these multiple undercurrents, Tripura is facing a multi-cornered contest for the first time in recent history.

THE SCHEDULE



Results: March 2

FACED WITH CRITICISM IN TRIPURA, THE BJP REPLACED CM BIPLAB DEB WITH MANIK SAHA, LIKE IT DID IN GUJARAT BEFORE THE POLLS